The Great Victoria Desert

Australia's largest sand-dune desert, shared between two states, dotted with rock pavement, and transected by shrubland

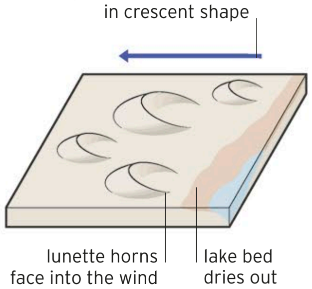
Stretching more than 440 miles (700 km) from west to east across parts of Western Australia and South Australia, the Great Victoria is the continent's largest, yet possibly least desertlike, desert. Although its average annual rainfall is just 6⅜ in (162 mm) and daytime temperatures are as high as 86–113°F (30–45°C), a surprising amount of plant life still manages to thrive here.

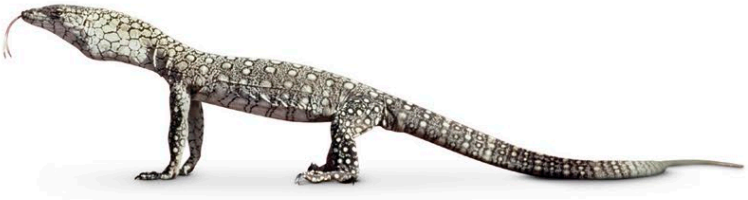
Under protection

Eucalyptus trees grow in parts of the region, while acacias and shrubland form a narrow, continuous strip known as the Giles Corridor that stretches across the desert's entire width. Clumps of spinifex, aristida, and other dry-adapted grasses also break up its dune fields and gibber plains (tightly packed layers of pebbles often covered with a layer of iron oxide). The desert has enough vegetation to attract many animals. It is famous for its reptiles, which number over 100 species, with geckos and skinks being particularly diverse. The region is also home to threatened mammals such as the marsupial mole and sandhill dunnart, and predators such as the dingo and Gould's goanna, a large monitor lizard that averages 3 ft (1 m) in length. The Great Victoria Desert's biodiversity has led to large sections being protected from development.

LUNETTE DUNES

Lunettes are fixed, crescent-shaped dunes found along the edges of temporary saline lakes, as in the Great Victoria Desert. Some are thought to occur due to wind-driven waves, which carry sediment into vegetation, where it becomes trapped.





▷ **POWERFUL PREDATOR**
The perentie is Australia's largest lizard and the largest goanna species. Growing up to 6 ft (2 m) long, this formidable predator charges at its prey at a speed of up to 20 mph (32 kph).

▽ **MORE THAN SAND**
Near Kati Thanda-Lake Eyre, Australia's largest salt lake, dunes and spinifex give way to mesas topped by silcrete, a hard layer of gravel and sand cemented together by silica.